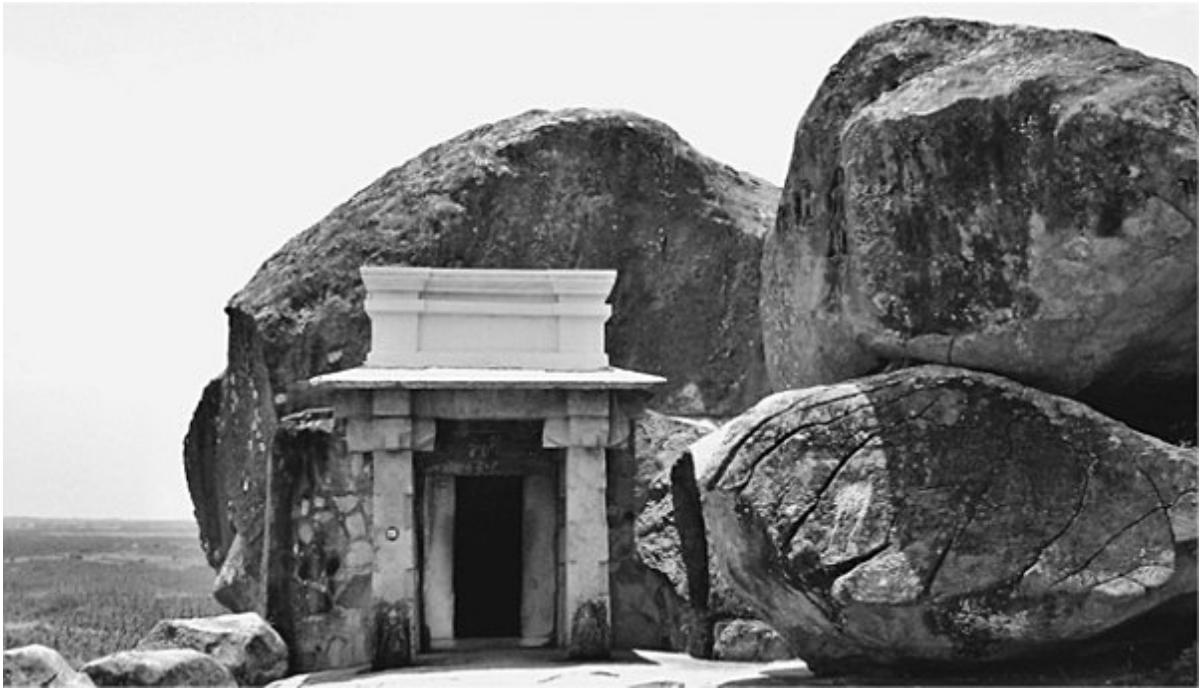


The Bhadrabahu Gupha (cave) on the same hill, where the ex-emperor Chandragupta Maurya is said to have fasted to death early in the third century BCE.

Among those who had accompanied Bhadrabahu's great trek south was his most important follower, none other than the first great emperor of India, Chandragupta Maurya, who had unified most of Northern India under one banner in about 316 BCE – only to become a Jain, renounce violence and abdicate in favour of his son Bindusara in order to join Bhadrabahu's epic migration south. That abdication probably took place just before or about 300 BCE, with Chandragupta's journey ending at Sravana Belgola. Having faithfully served his teacher until his death, the ex-emperor Chandragupta had then followed his example by becoming an ascetic, eventually choosing the moment of his own death by self-starvation.

Along with their religion, the Jain immigrants brought new ideas – hardly surprising, considering that they were led by well-educated monks versed in teaching and in such spheres of knowledge as mathematics. All the available